

POLITICAL

MATRIMONIALS

Upbeat about the upcoming Assembly elections in five states which are a prelude to next year's general elections, the party has begun scouting for new alliances



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■ By Bhavna Vij-Aurora

If appearances are any indication, the lotus is in full bloom. At the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) headquarters, the mood is upbeat ahead of the Assembly elections, to be held in five states starting next month. Party leaders are confident that the current mood of the nation will work to their advantage. "We are definitely going to win in four states," says a rather confident party President Rajnath Singh, referring to Delhi, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh. The fifth state, Mizoram, is no cause of concern since the state accounts for only one Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha seat each.

For the BJP, the results of the Assembly elections are crucial. Touted as the "mini general elections", the coming Assembly elections are important not only because they will indicate the way the wind is

blowing for the Lok Sabha elections early next year but also because a good showing may attract other parties to its fold thereby strengthening the National Democratic Alliance (NDA). "It is obvious that more people will join us if we do well in the Assembly polls. Not only will we have most of our old allies back with us, some new partners will also come," claims Singh, while refraining from giving details about who all the party is in touch with. "Some will join pre-poll and others may be post-poll partners," he says, without going into specifics.

All he is willing to say for the time being is that talks are on with some parties in the south, a region where they desperately need partners. In other regions, the BJP's efforts of wooing possible allies seem to be paying off, with Om Prakash Chautala's Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) in Haryana already on board. The now-reunited Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) has also agreed to be a

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